

North America

Cahokia

Location Illinois

Cahokia is the largest and most important pre-Columbian archaeological site in North America. It was the administrative, trading, and religious center of the Mississippian Culture (800–1600 CE), which extended across the southeastern US. At its height, in the 13th century, Cahokia covered more than 6 square miles (16 square km) and supported a population of 40,000. Its most distinctive feature was a series of devotional earth mounds, or temple pyramids, of which 80 survive. The largest, Monks Mound, is the largest pyramid in North America and the biggest prehistoric earthen structure

in the Americas. Its base extends over 657,000 square ft (61,000 square m)—comparable in size to that of the Great Pyramid of Giza (see pp.208–209). Built between 900 and 1200, it rises in four terraces, or steps, to a height of 98 ft (30 m). Its flat-topped summit was once the site of a wooden temple.

San Xavier del Bac

Location Tucson, Arizona

One of the finest examples of Spanish colonial architecture in the US, San Xavier del Bac was built by Franciscan missionaries between

1783 and 1797. Designed by Ignacio Gaona, the mission displays a synthesis of Moorish, Baroque, and native styles. Its brilliant white stucco exterior—which gives it the name the Dove of the Desert—is dominated by two massive, pierced square towers. These frame a three-story brick facade, featuring elaborate sculptures topped by a broken pediment. The 52-ft- (16-m-) high white dome sits over the transept. The imposing interior is richly decorated with multi-colored sculptures, paintings, and carvings featuring Spanish and Native American motifs.

Trinity Church

Location New York, New York

Trinity Church is the third church built on its site on Wall Street, lower Manhattan. Constructed out of locally sourced brownstone between 1839 and 1846 by British-

born architect Richard Upjohn, it was the tallest building in the US for 23 years. It is also the earliest example of Gothic Revival architecture in the country. An elegant, soaring building, the Trinity Church is dominated by a spire that rises 281 ft (86 m) over the main facade. The vertical accent is echoed in the nine slender turrets that stud each side of the roof of the nave. Prominent features of the church include the large stained-glass windows that bathe the interior in multicolored light and its three sets of bronze doors, which are modeled on those of the Florentine Baptistery (see pp.140–141).

Monadnock Building

Location Chicago, Illinois

Built between 1891 and 1893, the 16-story Monadnock Building, designed by Daniel Burham and

▼ THE BRIGHT AND ELEGANT EXTERIOR OF SAN XAVIER DEL BAC

